

need in whatever amount you want without requiring you to maintain a minimum balance. Some banks may require you to have a regular paycheck automatically deposited into your account in order to qualify for free checking.

- **Nearby ATM or branch locations.** Free ATM access is key. Banks don't charge you for using their own machines, but you will be charged for using ATMs that are affiliated with other banks. The fee your bank charges you for using a "foreign" ATM, as it is called, is on average \$2, but could be as high as \$3. So if you tend to use the ATM a lot, make sure you open a checking account at a bank with ATM locations near your work or home.
- **Online account access.** Online banking is a great way to monitor your accounts. You'll spot any bank errors much faster if you check your accounts online every week, instead of waiting for the monthly paper statement to arrive in the mail. Almost all banks offer free online account access with a checking account. This includes your statements and transaction history. Some banks will actually charge you for requesting paper statements, so if that matters to you, ask about it in advance.
- **Mobile banking.** If you're on the road a lot and can't get to a computer, see if your bank offers mobile banking. It will allow you to check your balances, pay bills, and transfer money between accounts, all from your cell phone—a handy tool for those on the go.

↓ **MANAGING YOUR CHECKING ACCOUNT**

Make sure you're managing your checking account wisely. If you don't, you could find yourself paying hundreds of dollars in fees. These fees are big business for banks. Here are some tips that will help you avoid such outrageous charges: